Three Mistakes Families Make When Mom's Care Arrangement Is Working

What each one looks like, why it happens, and the simple check that takes its place.

When Mom's week is running smoothly, nobody stops to ask how. Most families make the same three assumptions. None of them is careless, and each one is simple to check.

1 Assuming today's help will always be there

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE The neighbor has driven Mom to her appointments for three years, so the family plans as though she always will. Nobody else knows which days, and the appointment card lives on her fridge.

WHY IT HAPPENS Help that has never missed stops looking like something that could change. But people's weeks move. The National Institute on Aging says these arrangements may need revising over time, because family members' availability changes as well as the person's needs. [1]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Ask one question of every task: which of these depend on one person? List who does each thing and who else could, and write “only them” where you can't name anyone. The National Institute on Aging puts the question this way: other than the main helper, who can step in to help occasionally? What you end up with is a list of things to ask about, not a list of things that are wrong. [1]

2 Counting a backup nobody has agreed to

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE “If it came to that, Aunt Carol would step in.” Everyone in the family has said it. Aunt Carol may be the only one who hasn't heard.

WHY IT HAPPENS Naming someone feels like arranging something, and asking can feel like an imposition. It's common: the Family Caregiver Alliance tells caregivers without a backup plan that they are not alone, and names struggling to ask for help as one of the reasons. [2]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Ask her. The same page's first step is to think about who would most likely help, then talk with them about what might be needed and their willingness to step in. Write down what she says, with the date. Until then the entry beside her name is “assumed,” and that is a useful thing to know. [2]

3 Putting off writing down what isn't covered yet

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE Mom mentions she hasn't been to her Thursday card game in a while because the ride fell through. Everyone nods, and nobody writes it down. Nothing has gone wrong, so it doesn't seem to belong on any list.

WHY IT HAPPENS When things are fine, a small unmet need feels too minor to record. The National Institute on Aging notes that it is not always clear whether an aging parent needs help, and that some people may not want to cause worry. [3]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Ask the question plainly: what support is missing today? Write each answer as what happens now, in neutral words, with the date and who noticed: “Hasn't been to the Thursday card game since June. Her ride changed.” What a line like that means, and whether anything should change, isn't the list's job.

The one habit behind all three

Write down what's true today, who said it and when. Then note the changes that would bring the family back to the page.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say whether Mom's arrangement is enough or whether anything about it should change. It names three assumptions, the same three the Family Care Roadmap sees at this step, and a check for each.

Ready for the next step?

You know which three assumptions to check, and what to do in place of each. The care interview looks at the rest of Mom's week the same way: it goes through her daily life area by area, including the parts that run so smoothly nobody mentions them, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The points about changing availability, asking a likely helper about their willingness, and why a need can go unmentioned come from the sources below. The three mistakes are the Family Care Roadmap's own.

1. National Institute on Aging, Sharing Caregiving Responsibilities
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Smart Caregiving by FCA: Backup Planning
3. National Institute on Aging, Does an Older Adult in Your Life Need Help?

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